



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 22 PAGES

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

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INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 20~05~2026
-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-
"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"
Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You
Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or
indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.
There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing
of other topics in the main exam.

SC cites citizen's right to move freely, allows euthanasia of 'rabid, dangerous' stray dogs

Dismisses pleas against direction on relocation of stray canines

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, May 19

UNDERLINING THAT the right to live with dignity under Article 21 includes the right to move in public spaces without fear of dog bites, the Supreme Court on Tuesday allowed euthanasia of stray dogs if they are "rabid, incurably ill or demonstrably dangerous/aggressive", in accordance with the existing rules and laws.

Dismissing applications challenging the court's November 2025 directions on dealing with stray dogs, a three-judge bench of Justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and N V Anjaria said: "The right to live with dignity under Article 21 of the Constitution of India necessarily encompasses the right of every citizen to move freely and access public spaces without living under a constant appre-

EXPLAINED PAGE 15
QUESTIONS OF RIGHT TO LIFE, COMPASSION TO LIVING BEINGS

hension of physical harm, attack, or exposure to life-threatening events, such as dog bites in public areas."

"In areas where the population of stray dogs has assumed alarming proportions and where incidents of dog bites or aggressive attacks have become frequent and pose a continuing threat to public safety, the concerned authorities may, subject to due assessment by qualified veterinary experts, and strictly in accordance with the provisions of the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960, the Animal Birth Control (ABC) Rules and other applicable statutory protocols, take such measures as may be legally permissible, including euthanasia, in cases involving rabid, incurably ill or demonstrably dangerous/aggressive dogs so as to effectively curb the threat

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SUMMIT VOICES CONCERN OVER CHANGING WORLD ORDER



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with (from left) Norway PM Jonas Gahr Store, Finland PM Petteri Orpo, Sweden PM Ulf Kristersson, Iceland PM Kristrun Frostadottir and Denmark PM Mette Frederiksen at the Nordic-Indian summit at the City Hall in Oslo, Norway, Tuesday. AP

Green tech to innovation, India elevates ties with Nordic nations

PM: Nordic expertise, India's talent can develop trusted solutions for world

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, May 19

AS INDIA and Nordic countries agreed to transform ties into a Green Technology Partnership, leaders of all six countries Tuesday flagged concerns over glo-

bal tensions and turbulence in the international order. Prime Minister Narendra Modi said India and the Nordic nations will continue to stand together in upholding a "rules-based global order".

After the third India-Nordic

summit in Oslo, Modi said, "We have decided to shape the India-Nordic relationship into a strategic partnership focused on green technology and innovation. Through this Green Technology Partnership, by combining Iceland's expertise in geothermal energy and fisheries, Norway's strengths in the blue economy and Arctic affairs, and the maritime and

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

GROUPING TO MEET SEPTEMBER 12-13

Xi and Putin likely to be in Delhi for BRICS meet



Russian President Vladimir Putin with Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi after arriving in Beijing, Tuesday. REUTERS THE WORLD, P 18

China President's last visit to India was in Oct 2019, months before LAC standoff

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, May 19

RUSSIAN PRESIDENT Vladimir Putin and Chinese President Xi Jinping are likely to attend the New Delhi summit of BRICS leaders on September 12 and 13, sources told *The Indian Express* Tuesday.

It is learnt that the Russian and the Chinese sides have conveyed to New Delhi that their leaders are likely to come for

the summit.

Putin's presence at the summit was confirmed by Russian officials, according to Russian news agency TASS. He will also be attending the Shanghai Cooperation Organization summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan on August 31 and September 1. Prime Minister Narendra Modi too is likely to attend the SCO summit.

Sources said Xi's participation in the BRICS Summit is the most anticipated visit. It will be his first visit to India after October 2019 when he was at Mallapuram near Chennai for the second informal summit of India-China leaders.

Bilateral ties between India and China dived after a border standoff began in April-May 2020. The process of stabilisation of ties began after Modi

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BRICS

and Xi met on the sidelines of the BRICS summit in Kazan, Russia in October 2024. That was when the two sides decided to complete disengagement of troops at the Line of Actual Control in eastern Ladakh.

In the last year-and-half, India and China have made significant progress in stabilising relations with direct flights, resumption of visas, easing of

curbs on Chinese firms and the revival of the pilgrimage to Kailash Mansarovar.

However, more than 50,000 troops remain deployed along the LAC and the process of de-escalation and de-induction of troops have not yet taken place.

Barring any unforeseen developments, participation at the highest level has been conveyed to New Delhi. The venue has not yet been announced, but the Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi, sources said, is to be the likely choice of place for the summit.

Sources said the meeting of BRICS Foreign Ministers in New Delhi last week discussed the agenda for the summit of the leaders, and there was agreement on a range of issues for discussion.

While Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov participated in the meeting, Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi could not attend since he had to be in Beijing for the high-stakes meeting between Xi and US President Donald Trump. China's Ambassador to India, Xu Feihong, attended

the meeting on Wang's behalf.

Sources said the Indian government is also keen that the BRICS countries, which have been divided on the issue of the war in West Asia, should find common ground by the time the summit takes place.

With no consensus at the BRICS meeting last week on the diplomatic language for the West Asia war, India issued a chair statement, trying to balance the divergence between Iran and UAE, both members of the grouping.

Green tech

sustainability expertise of all Nordic nations with India's scale, we will ensure a better future for the entire world... By integrating Sweden's advanced manufacturing and defence capabilities, Finland's telecommunications and digital technologies, and Denmark's expertise in cybersecurity and health-tech with India's talent pool, we will develop trusted solutions for the global community."

"A crucial pillar of the India-Nordic partnership", he said, "lies in our extensive ties in research and innovation. To further strengthen this foundation, we will work together to enhance linkages among universities, laboratories, and start-up ecosystems. We will deepen our cooperation in Arctic and polar research, and ensure new opportunities for skill development and talent mobility between India and the Nordic countries."

"In this era of global tensions and conflicts, India and the Nordic nations will continue to stand together in upholding a rules-based global order. Whether in Ukraine or West Asia, we will continue to support efforts aimed at the early cessation of hostilities and the restoration of peace," he said.

Norway's PM Jonas Gahr Store, who hosted the summit in Oslo, said, "This meeting is a manifestation of what a more unpredictable world really needs: more cooperation and collaboration between democracies that, despite differences in geography and size and history, have a common approach to how we take on the big issues of our times."

Speaking of the growing geopolitical challenges they face, he said, "We have focused on support for international law, a rule-based order that also needs reforms and progress, and also emphasizing the need for a just and lasting peace in Ukraine and finding a way diplomatically on the ongoing conflict in the Middle East."

Denmark PM Mette Frederiksen also flagged the rules-based world order. "All of us standing here on the stage believe in a rule-based world order. Unfortunately, the old world order is changing rapidly, and it's not going in the right direction, and, therefore, it is even more important than before that partners who really believe in democracy actually work together, and this is exactly what we have been doing today."

Flagging "long-term reliable

ties", Swedish PM Ulf Kristersson, who met Modi in Gothenburg Sunday, said, "When we met two days ago in Sweden, together with a big business delegation from Sweden and around Europe, we came back to three key words all the time: it was innovation, it was scale, and it was the importance of long-term reliable relations. I think these are applicable also here today in the Nordic setting."

Finland's PM Petteri Orpo also flagged the "turbulence" in the current international order "characterized by geopolitical shifts, turbulence and uncertainty." "In these turbulent times, we continue to strengthen partnerships that are based on trust, mutual respect, as well as shared democratic values and interests." He also announced that Finland will host the next Nordic India Summit.

Talking about a "sense of hope", Iceland's PM Kristrun Frostadottir said: "This summit comes at a very poignant time for us. We can show that even though we are miles apart as a grouping as Nordics from India, but also for a country like Iceland, which is very different in scale and size, there are so many things that tie us together."

Modi, in his statement, said, "Our shared commitment to democracy, the rule of law, and multilateralism makes us natural partners. Furthermore, our shared priorities in technology and sustainability infuse our relationship with immense opportunities."

He said bilateral trade between India and the Nordic countries has nearly quadrupled over the last decade, and investments flowing from the Nordic nations into India have witnessed an increase of approximately 200 per cent over the past decade.

And on terrorism, Modi said, "We maintain a clear and united stance on terrorism: No compromise. No double standards."

"Although we speak different languages, sometimes a single word is sufficient to underscore the natural partnership that exists between us. Today, I used the word '*Sam-band*' several times. In many Nordic languages, the word signifies connection, relations, or a bond; in Hindi, it carries precisely the same meaning. This is not merely a linguistic coincidence. This reflects the convergence of our ideas. Let us deepen the ties between us in every sphere, and make the India-Nordic Partnership a model for shared prosperity, innovation, and a sustainable future," he said.

Stray dogs

posed to human life and safety," the court said.

It also said that animal welfare groups or student-led bodies in educational institutions which intend to take care of strays on campuses should mandatorily file an affidavit with the head of the institution, agreeing to undertake tortious liability in case of any stray dog bite, "failing which no such activity of maintaining or feeding stray dogs shall be permitted within the institutional premises." The court added that "failure to comply would entail suitable action against the head of the institution concerned."

In July last year, a two-judge bench of the SC had taken suo motu cognizance of rising instances of stray dog bites in Delhi. It issued a series of guidelines in August, including removal of stray dogs to shelters, and that canines picked up from a public area should not be returned to the same place after sterilisation/immunisation. The 2023 ABC Rules said "it is mandatory that the vaccinated and sterilised street dogs are released back to the exact location from where they were caught".

Animal lovers protested, and it was pointed out that there was another judgment, also by a two-judge bench, forbidding "any indiscriminate killings of canines" and advocating a more humane approach. The matter was then

referred to a three-judge bench.

On November 7, 2025, the three-judge bench issued a set of interim directions. It ordered that the canines be removed "forthwith" from the premises of educational institutions, hospitals, sports complexes, bus stands and depots, and railway stations to "a designated shelter, after due sterilisation and vaccination in accordance with the ABC Rules."

In the final order on Tuesday, the court held that the statutory scheme under the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960, and the ABC Rules, 2023, "does not mandate, nor can it be interpreted to require or justify the continued presence or re-release of stray dogs within institutional premises or other restricted-access areas." It noted that the "intended effect of... (its) directions has not yet adequately percolated to the ground level" and "the continued occurrence of such incidents reflects serious deficiencies in implementation and enforcement on the part of the concerned authorities."

It said that "any continued non-compliance or apathy in implementation of the directions... shall be viewed seriously, and the erring officials of the municipal authorities, and the concerned departments of the States and Union Territories shall render themselves reliable for appropriate proceedings, including proceedings for contempt of disciplinary proceedings and tortious liabilities."

APPROVAL BOOSTS DEFENCE TIES BETWEEN THE TWO COUNTRIES

US clears Apache, howitzer support services for India

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, May 19

THE US has approved the proposed sale of support services and related equipment for Apache helicopters to India at an estimated cost of \$198.2 million, noting that this will improve Delhi's "capability to meet current and future threats, strengthen its homeland defence, and deter regional threats".

In a statement, the US Department of State said it also approved a possible sale of sustainment support for M777A2 Ultra-Light Howitzers for an estimated cost of \$230 million.

The developments come at a time when the US and India are in the final stages of negotiating a comprehensive bilateral trade agreement, after having established a framework for an interim trade pact.

In November last year, the US approved the sale of Excalibur projectiles, the Javelin missile system, and other related equipment to India for over \$90 million. Around the same time, India signed Letters of Offer and

E. EXPLAINED

Rubio visit on May 23

Defence ties between India and the US have not just survived but deepened despite the strain in relations following the Trump administration's imposition of tariffs last year. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio will visit India from May 23-26 for a meeting of Foreign Ministers of the Quad countries. During his visit, he will travel to New Delhi, Kolkata, Agra and Jaipur. He will hold talks on energy security, trade and defence with senior officials.

Acceptance (LOAs) with the US for sustainment support of the Indian Navy's fleet of MH60R helicopters through Follow on Support and Follow on Supply Support for a period of five years worth Rs 7,995 crore.

Additionally, the Indian Defence Acquisition Committee, earlier this year, cleared the acquisition of six P-8I maritime

surveillance and anti-submarine warfare aircraft from the US for the Indian Navy.

According to a statement from the Department of State, India had requested to buy AH-64E Apache sustainment support services; US government and contractor engineering, technical, and logistics support services; technical data and publications; personnel training; and other related elements of logistics and programme support.

It said the proposed sale will improve "India's capability to meet current and future threats, strengthen its homeland defence, and deter regional threats. India will have no difficulty absorbing these articles and services into its armed forces."

It noted that the principal contractor will be Boeing and Lockheed Martin.

In a separate statement, it said India had requested to buy long-term sustainment support for M777A2 Ultra-Light Howitzers, which includes ancillary items; spares; repair and return; training; technical assistance; field service representative; depot capability; and

other related elements of logistics and program support. The principal contractor for this will be BAE Systems.

"This proposed sale will support the foreign policy and national security objectives of the United States by helping to strengthen the US-Indian strategic relationship and to improve the security of a major defense partner which continues to be an important force for political stability, peace, and economic progress in the Indo-Pacific and South Asia regions," the statement said about both the sales.

"The proposed sale of this equipment and support will not alter the basic military balance in the region," it said.

In October last year, the two countries signed the 'framework for the US-India major defence partnership', signalling stable ties in the defence sector. The vision for bilateral defence cooperation was encapsulated in the September 2013 Joint US-India Declaration on Defence Cooperation and the 2015 Framework for the US-India Defence Relationship.

'India should have important role in being a great partner (of Chile) — in services, tech'

CHILE'S FOREIGN Minister **Francisco Pérez Mackenna** recently met External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal during his visit months after the newly elected government, led by President Jose Antonio Kast, assumed office this March. In an interview with **Shubhajt Roy**, he spoke about cooperation on critical minerals, Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement talks, ties with the US and China, defence and strategic cooperation with Delhi, collaboration in Antarctica and the impact of the West Asia war.



cooperation?

Normally in the past, when you talked about value added, people were thinking of industrial policy and like the government's wanting to direct what the private sector was doing through subsidies and taxes. We want to ensure the markets in particular, critical minerals, but also in other other products, are not only efficient but transparent and fair... And that implies necessarily, not to look only at the best price, but also at how the structure of the market is being organised. So you don't get monopoly powers and distortions... highly concentrated markets are the problem. We want to make sure more parties join the club, and we can diversify.

What was the focus of your visit in Delhi, especially after a change in government in Chile, from Left government to a right-wing government?

We are less than two months into office. India is a first priority for us. The reason we came here is two-fold — is to open markets further, to trade more with India, and also to foster investment in Chile from India, so we can establish Chile as a hub for the rest of the world, particularly in services that require human capital, especially in the digital economy. Chile is probably one of the most open countries in the world to trade. We have more than 60 FTAs with the world.

We want countries to "Choose Chile" as the best place to do business.

We are going to be very relevant for the world in critical minerals and rare earths. We are to have around 30% of the world reserves of lithium and copper... And these are going to be key ingredients for the future of AI revolution for data centres and AI factories, but we need to use that opportunity to create other platforms for growth. We want to trade much more with India. And that implies investments and long-term commitments.

You talked about the critical minerals, and India is especially interested in the lithium and copper reserves that Chile has. What is the status of the

Last year, when Chile's President visited India, there was a push to CEPA negotiations. What is the status a year after the talks were launched?

We have been progressing, and we have been talking... Now we need to write these things and negotiate the elements that are missing. Maybe we can get this accomplished this year. But more important than speed is quality of what we do, because these agreements will be used as a framework to make investment decisions that are going to be around for 40-50 years.

How do you view India's presence in Latin America?

India has a presence in Chile in building a power line that will connect the parts of Chile in the North. I have personal experiences in the past in computing services and software. We see the potential of India becoming a much more significant player in Chile, we have a similar structure in terms of how we organise our countries, in terms of rule of law and democracy. India is a very good partner.

Is there a big picture message after you met Jaishankar?

The most important message is we want not only you, but the world to "Choose Chile"... because we're going to be a very reliable supplier of important goods like critical minerals, but also best quality food, fruits, vegetables, fish, pulp, paper. We also want to be a very good host for Indian human capital if you want to consider Chile as a possibility to serve at least the Western world (because of) our time zone.

How is Chile's relationship with the US under President Trump, since your President has a similar worldview?

We want to have a good relationship with everybody, we want that foreign relations to be managed in the best interest of the Chilean people. And so in that regard, sometimes we have to put our political preferences and ideologies aside. The US has always been a traditional, strong partner of Chile... the US is the most important factory of human capital and high tech in the world. So, to a large extent, that means the US is the future, and we can't walk away from our future... China is our most important trade partner. We will continue to trade extensively with China, and India should have a very important role in being a great partner, both for the present in terms of goods and services, but also for the future in terms of tech. The message is we'll always work our foreign relations in the best interest of our people, and that implies a long-term view. **FULL INTERVIEW**

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Focus on defence ties, maritime security: Rajnath meets Vietnamese counterpart

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, May 19

DEFENCE MINISTER Rajnath Singh on Tuesday met his Vietnamese counterpart, General Phan Văn Giang, in Hanoi, where they reviewed the growing partnership between the two countries and discussed ways to deepen cooperation in maritime security, defence industry, training and regional stability.

According to a statement issued by the Ministry of Defence, the two sides exchanged views on regional and global security developments of mutual interest, and emphasised the importance of maintaining peace, stability, security, safety and freedom of navigation in the Indo-Pacific region.

They also discussed avenues to expand cooperation in areas including military training, defence industry collaboration, maritime security, capacity building, United Nations peacekeeping, cyber security and high-level exchanges, the statement read, adding that they have agreed to enhance cooperation between the defence forces through regular dialogues, joint exercises and exchange programmes.

The bilateral defence engagements have expanded over the years, and include wide-ranging contacts between the two countries, such as defence policy dialogues, military-to-military exchanges, high-level visits, capacity-building and training programmes, cooper-



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh receives a ceremonial Guard of Honour at the headquarters of the Ministry of National Defence, in Hanoi on Tuesday. Minister of National Defence of Vietnam, Senior Lieutenant General Phan Văn Giang, is also present. **ANI**

ation in UN peacekeeping, ship visits and bilateral exercises.

In June 2022, when Singh last visited Hanoi, both countries signed the 'Joint Vision Statement on India-Vietnam Defence Partnership Towards 2030', as well as inked a memorandum of understanding (MoU) on mutual logistics support to strengthen bilateral defence cooperation.

India had handed over 12 high-speed guard boats to Vietnam at the time, and also announced gifting two simulators

and a monetary grant towards setting up a Language and IT laboratory at the Air Force Officers' Training School in Vietnam's Nha Trang.

In July 2023, India gifted the INS Kirpan to Vietnam, complete with its weapon complement, after decommissioning it following 32 years of service. This marked the first instance where India gifted an indigenously built missile corvette to Vietnam.

The development was significant amid a growing Chi-

nese influence in the South China Sea, which had led to territorial disputes with Vietnam. Vietnam, among others, have been looking at buying BrahMos supersonic missiles from India.

According to the statement, Singh reaffirmed the commitment to strengthening India's enhanced comprehensive strategic partnership with Vietnam, while reiterating India's resolve to support the country's defence modernisation and capacity enhancement initiatives.

Moon's upper surface has two distinct layers within centimetres, reveals Chandrayaan-3 'hop' experiment

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, May 19

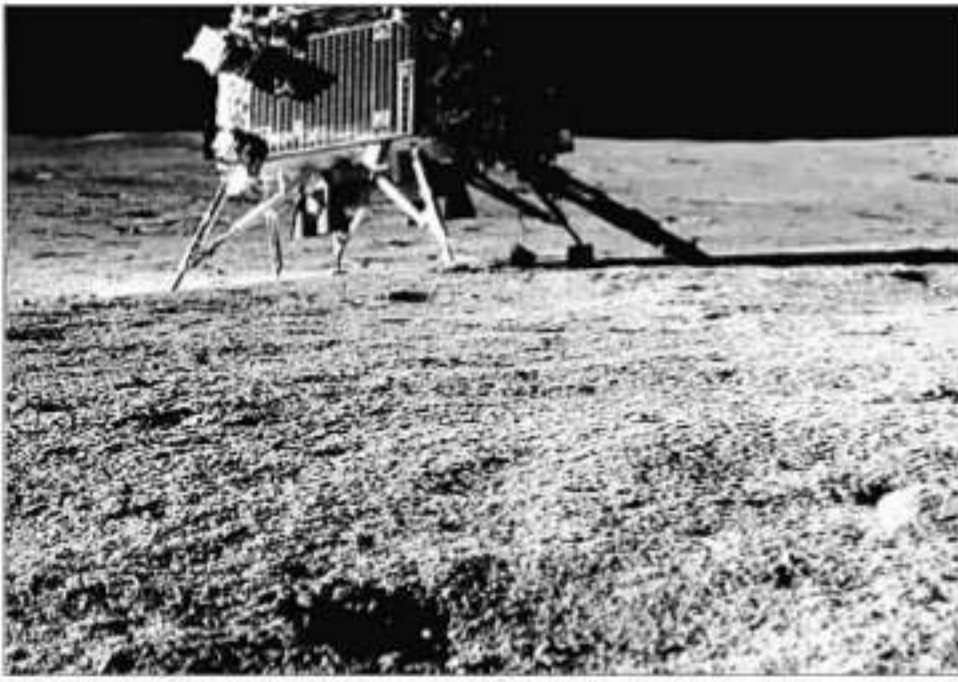
THE FAMOUS 'hop' experiment performed by the Chandrayaan-3 lander on the Moon was not just about demonstrating Indian space agency ISRO's ability to launch from the lunar surface. Scientists have now revealed new details about the upper surface of the Moon at the landing site using data collected during that 'hop' manoeuvre performed towards the end of planned active mission life of Chandrayaan-3.

In new findings published in the Astrophysical Journal, scientists from the Physical Research Laboratory (PRL) in Ahmedabad have reported that the Moon's upper surface, the regolith as it is called, is not uniform, and its physical and thermal properties show sharp changes at just a few centimetres of depth. The loose porous layer at the top very quickly gives way to a denser compact layer just 2 to 6 cm below.

More importantly, the

paper, which is based on analysis of data produced by the ChaSTE (Chandra's Surface Thermophysical Experiment), suggests that the 'hop' experiment disturbed the upper loose layer enough to expose the subsequent layers to the instruments onboard the lander.

On September 4, 2023, just before it went into hibernation to survive the lunar night, the Chandrayaan-3 lander, which had made a historic soft-landing 10 days earlier, was made to perform a small jump. The lander fired its engines, lifted itself up about 40 cm from the surface, and landed again 30-40 cm away. The 'hop' experiment was never publicised in the Chandrayaan-3 plans and had come as a surprise. It was seen as a demonstration of the capability of ISRO to get the lander to fire its engines and produce enough thrust to lift itself up from the surface. This capability is key for future missions in which the spacecraft would be required to make the return journey to the Earth.



The lander was made to perform a small jump on Sep 4, 2023. ISRO

The new findings have put a more precise measurement for the distance travelled by lander during the 'hop' experiment -- about 50 cm, instead of the earlier estimate of 30-40 cm. The paper says that the rocket plume generated during the 'hop' was enough to blow away about 3 cm of the top layer of the surface, and allow the ChaSTE to have a look at the newly exposed layer

beneath. A rod-shaped probe with a sharp tip and fitted with temperature sensors, ChaSTE was able to do a thermal profile of the new site post 'hop'. It was deployed for 57 minutes during lunar twilight, which lasts for a few hours unlike the Earth twilight that lasts for a few minutes before sunset. The analysis revealed that even at depths of 6 to 9 cm, the lunar surface was

E. EXPLAINED

Mining information

Data from instruments onboard Chandrayaan-3 mission are continuing to generate very useful information about the Moon. ChaSTE, one of the four instruments on the lander, has itself produced at least three major papers in important international publications until now.

composed of two distinct layers.

The paper represents a first-of-its-kind thermal profile, density and layering structure of the Moon's surface at the lunar twilight time, just ahead of sunset on this part of the Moon. The information could be useful at the time of planning future moon walks or for building lunar bases, PRL scientists said.

Specifically, the amount of

displacement caused by rocket plumes at the time of the 'hop' experiment is very useful information for space agencies planning return missions. It helps them to understand what to expect when a rocket engine is fired so close to the surface.

Data from ChaSTE has resulted in other findings as well, which have been published earlier. Last year, the same group of scientists had reported that water-ice on the Moon could be more prevalent than understood earlier. Using ChaSTE data, they had reported that there was a good probability that water-ice was present in locations outside of the polar regions of the Moon.

In another publication, scientists had shown that temperature of the lunar surface dropped drastically with depth. At depths of just 10 cm, the temperature was about 60 degree Celsius less than at the surface. Such extreme heat non-conductivity was considered very useful information from the perspective of creating temperature-controlled habitats on the Moon.



The Editorial Page

WEDNESDAY, MAY 20, 2026

Look beyond strategic autonomy, and closer at the Quad possibility



RAJA MANDALA
BY C RAJA MOHAN

On bail, Court must heed rule it laid down

THE SUPREME Court decision granting bail to a person accused in a narco-terrorism case in J&K, in which he had been incarcerated as an undertrial under the UAPA for five years, is significant for more than one reason. The bench comprising Justices B V Nagarathna and Ujjal Bhuyan has reiterated that even the rigours of stringent bail provisions in terror cases would “melt down” when prolonged incarceration and delayed trial produce a violation of Article 21 of the Constitution, which guarantees the individual’s right to life and personal liberty. It also did something the Court rarely does: It called out its own deviation from the rule.

In the 2001 ruling in *K A Najeed*, the SC laid down that an undertrial suffering prolonged incarceration with completion of trial not in sight must be granted bail — even under the Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA). However, the establishment of this rule has been followed by a plurality of judicial approaches, with some benches abiding by the “good law”, and others deviating from it. A notable deviation came in the January 2026 order in the bail hearing of the accused in the North-East Delhi riots. For those who were granted bail in the case, the reason cited was not delay, which the *Najeed* ruling required, but that they figured lower in a “hierarchy of offences” that the Court created. For Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam, the Court said that their prolonged incarceration had not crossed the “threshold of constitutional impermissibility”. Justice Nagarathna’s bench has now wisely cautioned that if a smaller bench disagrees with a larger one, it must refer the case to the Chief Justice of India, not deviate from it and render the rule meaningless. It is nobody’s case that mechanical consistency must replace judicious interpretation, especially in a polyvocal court with 34 judges. However, some principles are irrefutable. As the bench underlined: “Ideally, the more serious the accusations are, the speedier the trial should be.”

At a time when legislation carves out increasingly sweeping definitions of crimes, even as punishments become harsher, the SC bench’s intervention is much needed. The Court cited NCRB data, noting that the countrywide conviction rate under the UAPA for the five years between 2019 and 2023 hovers between 2 and 6 per cent — that is, a 94 to 98 per cent probability of acquittal in such cases nationally. In J&K, the conviction rate has remained below 1 per cent. In public speeches, judges often repeat the adage “bail is the rule, jail is the exception”, as former CJD Y Chandrachud did in 2024, days before demitting office. But the judiciary needs to do more than just that. Especially in cases that involve the protection of fundamental liberties against state abuse, the Court must listen to itself, and abide by its better instincts.

World isn’t prepared for next pandemic

ON SUNDAY, the World Health Organisation declared the Ebola outbreak in Uganda and the Democratic Republic of Congo a “public health emergency of international concern”. More than 500 people have contracted the viral disease and at least 130 have succumbed to it in the two countries in the past two weeks. The WHO has warned that the scale of the outbreak is “likely larger” than these figures suggest. The emergency involves the Bundibugyo strain of the virus, for which there are no vaccines or therapeutics. The crisis has assumed even graver proportions because the global health agency’s ability to mount an effective response has been undermined by funding cuts, after the US withdrew from the organisation in January. Germany, France, the Netherlands and the UK have also slashed their funding for the agency, forcing it to reduce its 2026-2027 budget by about 8 per cent. The cuts have reportedly weakened disease surveillance systems in conflict-ridden areas such as the Democratic Republic of Congo.

After the Covid pandemic, there was broad agreement that the world required a binding international framework to respond to a health emergency. The adoption of the Global Pandemic Treaty in May last year had generated hope that countries, barring the US, could come together to forge a robust health-security architecture. But the treaty was under stress even before it was ratified. Rich countries have been reluctant to commit to mandatory technology transfers or binding obligations on sharing medical resources during crises. Developing nations continue to distrust a system that allowed vast inequalities during the Covid vaccine rollout.

In the post-Covid years, the ability to detect emerging threats and develop medical countermeasures has improved appreciably. With advances in vaccine platforms, particularly mRNA technology, pharma researchers can design inoculation programmes at a much faster pace than in pre-Covid times. Yet, as the latest report of the Global Preparedness Monitoring Board — co-convened by the World Bank and WHO — points out, “the world is not ready to take on the next pandemic”. The Ebola outbreak is a stark reminder that containing infectious disease requires sustained investment in healthcare, scientific cooperation and international collaboration.

THOSE IN Delhi who are antsy about US President Donald Trump’s visit to Beijing and the prospect of a Sino-American détente should be even more worried as Xi Jinping serenades Vladimir Putin in Beijing this week. Those perennially anxious about a G-2 between the US and China should worry even more about China’s deepening partnership with Russia. One of the core arguments for Russia’s centrality in India’s national strategy is that it serves as a balancing power in Eurasia. But the Eurasian story of the last quarter-century is about Russia’s growing bonds with China — India’s principal challenge in both economic and geopolitical terms.

If Trump’s visit was about moving the US from confrontation to stabilisation of ties with China, Putin’s is about celebrating the strategic partnership unveiled 25 years ago. Since Putin’s invasion of Ukraine in 2022, Russia has become even more dependent on China. What do the two pilgrimages to Beijing mean for India?

First, India should not be rattled by every shift in great-power relations. Since World War II, relations among the US, China and Russia have changed repeatedly, often violently. Taken in pairs, they have been allies,

friends, enemies and frenemies at different moments. Dealing with that change is part of the national mandate.

Second, the real challenge for India is addressing the consequences of China’s rise and assertion. Since the 1980s, China’s relative power — economic, technological and military — has grown rapidly against every other actor in the system. For India, the problem is especially acute: A long, disputed and tension-prone boundary; Beijing’s growing influence in India’s neighbourhood; an expanding Chinese footprint in global institutions; and a trade deficit now above \$110 billion, rooted in India’s deepening dependence on Chinese manufactured goods.

Third, the answer lies partly in accelerating India’s own rise. Shifts in great-power relations, the emergence of wars and global crises — these are variables India cannot control. What it can drive is its own modernisation. Although India has performed well on several fronts in the reform era that began in the early 1990s, its uneven scope and unsteady pace mean the gap with China is growing. China’s economy is today five times larger, and the disparity in higher education, R&D, technology and military capability is widening.

Fourth, India cannot close the gap with China anytime soon, but it can reduce the impact of the power imbalance through external cooperation that reinforces internal self-strengthening. Much like China, India has turned to the West for capital, export markets, technology and regional security. Since the 1990s, engagement with the US and Europe has grown rapidly.

Elevation of that engagement to

Shifts in great-power relations, the emergence of wars and global crises — these are variables India cannot control. What it can drive is its own modernisation

higher levels is obstructed by an enduring suspicion of the US and the West in the Indian political mind, across Left and Right. Anti-imperialists and nativists alike have long united in limiting significant Western cooperation. It is this sentiment that gives sustenance to the idea of “strategic autonomy” — a term framed as neutral, but whose political content has always been about maintaining distance from the West. If the US and Europe were the problem, the answer was seen as lying in deeper ties with Russia and China, bilaterally, trilaterally and in multilateral forums.

This discourse, constructed in the 1990s, has run into a fundamental problem: An assertive China has become India’s principal challenge, Russia has become rising China’s most important partner, and India’s stakes in Western partnership have grown enormously. You may say the US under Trump is unreliable — but it is not occupying Indian territory. It is India’s largest export market, a major source of technology, and home to an influential diaspora.

Consider this number: India exports more goods to the Netherlands — a country of 19 million people — than to China and Russia combined. There is no starker illustration of how far Indian strategic discourse has drifted from basic economic reality.

While Russia and China dominate India’s mindspace, the Netherlands and other small but important European partners barely figure in India’s debates. Independent India, which long privileged the Russian partnership over European ones, is now making amends. The Indian discourse may have acquired “strategic autonomy”

from the imperatives on the ground, but the government has had no choice but to reconnect foreign policy to first principles, reflected in the fact that India fought to preserve its trade relationship with the US, has pushed hard for a trade deal with the EU, and has focussed on deeper technology cooperation with both in the last two years.

Hosting the Quad foreign ministers’ meeting early next week follows the same logic. The Quad’s revival a decade ago was rooted in the need to build a multipolar Asia amid intensifying challenges from China. One Trump visit to Beijing does not alter that imperative. Over the last decade, several voices in Delhi warned that the Quad would “entrap” India in a military alliance against China and insisted on slow-walking it. Many of the same voices now say the US is about to “abandon” India. The government has taken a more measured view and has actively sustained several rounds of official consultations with Quad partners.

The enthusiasm to write obituaries for the Quad may be both premature and excessive. The visit of Secretary of State Marco Rubio — who also serves as Trump’s National Security Adviser — provides a valuable opportunity to get a first-hand account of the US-China summit, assess Washington’s changing approach to alliances, and develop a productive and sustainable agenda for the Quad.

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In CDS appointments, some unanswered questions



C UDAY BHASKAR

LIEUTENANT GENERAL N S Raja Subramani (retd) has been appointed India’s next Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) and Secretary, Department of Military Affairs (DMA). He will be India’s third CDS after the late General Bipin Rawat and General Anil Chauhan.

The post of CDS was created during Modi 2.0 in December 2019, and Gen Rawat, after completing his tenure as Army chief, was the first to be appointed to the post. Tragically, Gen Rawat died in a helicopter crash in December 2021, and many structural changes that had been envisioned (nurturing jointness, creating theatre commands, and scaling up self-reliance in military inventory) remained incomplete. It was only at the end of September 2022 that the second CDS was appointed.

The choice was a surprise, in that the Modi government decided to appoint a retired three-star officer, then-Lt Gen Chauhan, and promote him to four-star. This was unprecedented, and while the government created the legal basis in June 2022 by amending the service rules to allow serving or retired lieutenant generals (and equivalents) under the age of 62 to be appointed CDS, it created an anomalous disruption in India’s hallowed military traditions. Promotions in the military have a deeply ingrained sanctity; an incongruous precedent was set wherein a retired officer was brought back into uniform and promoted. The spirit of the military rule book does not have any provision to “promote” retired officers and bring them back to active duty.

The same pattern is being repeated: To select a retired three-star officer and “promote” him to four-star. The inferences that follow are that the government was unable to identify a serving officer to be appointed CDS, and that the net had to be cast wide to include some retired three-stars.

Lt Gen Subramani is an officer of proven competence and has held the highest appointments for a three-star Army officer, namely army commander and vice chief of the Army. However, what may have tipped the scales in his favour is

that he has been serving as military adviser to the National Security Council Secretariat (NSCS) since September 2025. This is similar to the career path of Gen Chauhan, who served in the NSCS from October 2021 till his appointment as CDS in September 2022.

Thus, the first inference is that an NSCS appointment is the route for an aspiring CDS and that a deep selection process among retired military top brass, particularly the Army, is carried out by the government. A formulation being advanced is that the Modi government has retained the seniority principle in appointing service chiefs but has adopted the merit yardstick in selecting the CDS. But what are the criteria for this critical selection? This post has a consequential bearing on national military security. How is merit adjudged, and amongst which cohort of retired officers?

On current evidence, the related inference is that only retired Army officers have been considered for CDS. This reflects a deeply ingrained policy orientation in South Block that the Army, as the largest among the three services, is best suited for the CDS post. The scope and ambit of conflict is now multidimensional and calls for appropriate experience and background at higher military echelons. Acquiring and harnessing transborder military capability in the larger national interest is the new challenge for major nations, and restricting the CDS choice to the retired Army gene pool would have excluded equally deserving officers from the other two services.

The incongruous practice of first identifying a retired three-star general, then grooming the individual to assume office as CDS, and further “promoting” the veteran to four-star rank (when no such provision exists) introduces a political filter that is better avoided. It is anomalous and disheartening for the “*fauj*” that the government does not consider any serving three- or four-star officer as being fit to be the CDS. There are many daunting challenges ahead for the new CDS. Fair winds and following seas, General Subramani.

The writer is director, Society for Policy Studies, New Delhi

The scope and ambit of conflict is now multidimensional and calls for appropriate experience and background at higher military echelons

India and Italy look to the future, bound by the power of culture and a shared vision



NARENDRA MODI
AND GIORGIA MELONI

THE RELATIONSHIP between India and Italy has now reached a decisive stage. In recent years, our ties have expanded with unprecedented momentum, evolving from a cordial friendship into a special strategic partnership grounded in the values of freedom and democracy, and a common vision for the future.

At a time when the international system is undergoing a profound change, the partnership between Italy and India is guided by regular exchanges at higher political and institutional levels, and is gaining a new and higher dimension that combines our economic dynamism, societal creativity, and millennia-old civilisational wisdom. Our cooperation mirrors our shared awareness that prosperity and security in the 21st century will be shaped by the ability of nations to innovate, manage energy transitions, and strengthen strategic sovereignty. To this end, we have committed to deepening and diversifying our bilateral relationship with a view to pursuing new objectives and pooling our complementary strengths. We aim to forge a powerful synergy between Italian design, manufacturing excellence, and world-class supercomputers — reflecting Italy's position as an industrial powerhouse — and India's rapid economic growth, engineering talent, scale, and innovation and entrepreneurial ecosystem with over 100 unicorns and 200,000 start-ups. This is not a simple integration, but a co-creation of value where our respective industrial strengths amplify one another.

The free trade agreement between the European Union and India paves the way for increased trade and investment in both directions. We want to reach and exceed the €20 billion target for trade between Italy and India by 2029, with a focus on defence and aerospace, clean technologies, machinery, automotive components, chemicals, pharmaceuticals, textiles, agri-food, tourism and more.

"Made in Italy" has always been synonymous with excellence worldwide, and today it finds a natural synergy with the high-quality goals of the "Make in India" initiative.



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

In this context, the growing interest of Italian businesses in production for India and the increasing presence of Indian industries in Italy, numbering over 1,000 from both sides now, is a positive sign that will strengthen the integration of our supply chains.

Technological innovation lies at the very heart of our partnership. The coming decades will be shaped by a technological revolution of unmeasurable scope, marked by advances in sectors such as artificial intelligence, quantum computing, advanced manufacturing, critical minerals, and digital infrastructure. India's dynamic innovation ecosystem, coupled with a highly skilled professional talent pool, and Italy's advanced industrial capabilities, make our cooperation in the above sectors both natural and strategic. The growing partnership between our universities and research centres will support this. India's digital public infrastructure is already finding resonance with a large number of countries, particularly in the Global South.

Artificial intelligence, in particular, is already impacting our societies and the global economy. Italy and India have long been collaborating to ensure that AI development is responsible and human-centred. From this perspective, India and Italy also see AI as a powerful instrument for inclusive development, especially for the Global South, where digital public infrastructure and accessible, multilingual technologies can bridge divides rather than deepen them. Building on India's vision of MANAV — putting humans at the centre of technology — and Italy's leadership in promoting a human-centric "algor-ethics" rooted in its humanist tradition, our partnership seeks to ensure that AI acts as

Our cooperation mirrors our shared awareness that prosperity and security in the 21st century will be shaped by the ability of nations to innovate, manage energy transitions, and strengthen strategic sovereignty

a catalyst for social empowerment. Our approach combines India's digital scale with Italy's ethical and industrial expertise, ensuring technology serves human dignity.

By sharing best practices in secure digital cooperation, capacity-building and resilient cyber infrastructure, we aim to create an open, trustworthy and equitable digital space in which every nation can shape and benefit from AI. This perspective forms the core of Italy's G7 presidency and the outcomes of the AI Impact Summit 2026, held in New Delhi. Conceiving AI as a tool created by humans for humans means firmly asserting that technology cannot replace individuals or undermine their fundamental rights, nor be used to manipulate public debate or alter democratic processes. Our approach to defending freedom and human dignity in an increasingly interconnected world hinges on this very challenge.

Our cooperation also covers the space sector. India's impressive advancements in space exploration and satellite technology, together with Italy's aerospace engineering excellence, offer significant opportunities for joint initiatives and next-generation technology development.

Security and stability remain essential to ensuring nations' prosperity. Italy and India intend to further strengthen their cooperation in sectors such as defence, security and strategic technologies. Our collaboration will help ensure the security of critical maritime routes and strengthen resilience in the face of threats such as terrorism, international criminal networks, drug trafficking, cybercrime and human trafficking.

Energy is another key pillar of our partnership. The global transition towards diversified energy

sources requires innovation, investment, and cooperation. India and Italy are collaborating, from renewable energy to hydrogen technologies, and from smart grids to resilient infrastructure. While India's push to become a hub for green hydrogen exports offers immense potential, it perfectly complements Italy's advanced technology in renewable infrastructure and its strategic role as an energy gateway for Europe. Our collaboration along with other countries in key India-led initiatives — International Solar Alliance (ISA), Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI) and Global Biofuels Alliance (GBA) — is also important in this context.

Physical, digital and human connectivity is the thread that weaves us together. Both India and Italy are located at the very heart of two crucial hubs of the global economy, the Indo-Pacific and the Mediterranean — regions that cannot be viewed as separate spheres, but instead as increasingly interconnected spaces. As a matter of fact, we are witnessing the emergence of what might be termed the Indo-Mediterranean, an important corridor for trade, technology, energy, data and ideas tying the Indian Ocean to Europe. It is precisely within this interconnected space that our bond naturally evolves into a special strategic partnership — one that bridges two continents and shapes new global dynamics.

In this context, the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) represents a vision aimed at connecting our regions through modern transport and infrastructure, digital networks, energy systems, and resilient supply chains. India and Italy are also committed to working together with other partners to make this vision a reality.

We can address our shared challenges by drawing upon the profound partnership and enduring cultural ties between our nations. Within Indian culture, the concept of *dharma* evokes the sense of responsibility that must guide our actions, whilst the principle of *vasudhaiva kutumbakam* — the world is one family — resonates powerfully in this interconnected digital age. Such values find a natural echo in Italy's humanist tradition, rooted in the Renaissance, which highlights the dignity of each individual and the power of culture to unite peoples and societies. Our shared vision, therefore, aims to lay the foundation for a strong and forward-looking India-Italy partnership with our people at the centre.

Modi is Prime Minister of India and Meloni is President of the Council of Ministers of the Italian Republic

Let's make do with less, but also find substitutes quickly



PULAPRE BALAKRISHNAN

THE PRIME Minister's list of measures to curb consumption of imported goods, mainly gold and oil, somehow got named "austerity" in the public discourse. In Economics, the term is used somewhat differently in the context of a crisis. I shall return to it, having first considered the PM's proposals.

Restrictions on imports are standard when a country faces a balance of payments crisis, leaving it starved of foreign exchange. In India, gold is the go-to store of value, reflecting the underdevelopment of financial instruments historically. Even where financial instruments for saving exist, the returns may not be inflation-indexed. Gold's lure is that its value rises continuously with inflation. However, saving in the form of gold does not end up with investors. It is, therefore, a "curse" for the economy, as potential purchasing power gets locked up. There is also the additional factor that we produce next to no gold even as we display a voracious appetite for it. As the import of gold is a leakage of demand and it is not an input into necessary production, there is a case for reducing it.

The case of oil is altogether different. It is the quintessential intermediate input, entering production directly or indirectly. Thus, if there is less of it, it will lower output and employment unless efficiency rises or substitutes are found. The same is true of LPG supplies. It has been said that the current shortage has been forced upon India by the war in West Asia, but it is not clear that the government made any effort to secure oil from Russia and Iran defying US President Donald Trump's sanctions.

Be that as it may, there is no denying the potential hardships ahead. To avoid this, alternative sources of energy will have to be found. Domestically produced electricity will have to replace imported oil and gas. A shift to electric cars would be costly for India, for unlike China, it does not yet have the capacity to produce them at scale. But a shift to electricity for cooking is entirely



feasible. However, it is not a choice that can be made from Delhi. Electricity is generated at the level of states. For decades, the state electricity boards have been forced to supply electricity cheaply to select groups. It is questionable whether they have the capacity to rapidly ramp up the supply needed to replace LPG.

The declining cost and rising availability of solar power in India, too, is irrelevant. The Kerala State Electricity Board, for instance, has conveyed that it does not have the funds to invest in the equipment needed to store the electricity generated by households. Such funds will have to be found, though, as geopolitics is likely to keep India under pressure. In fact, this is the perfect moment for India to strive for a dual energy transition, from foreign to domestic sources of supply and from fossil fuels to renewable energy sources. So, while the PM's exhortation makes sense, the government must lay out clearly how energy from alternative sources can be found. The government's regulatory bodies have also been far too lax in bringing automakers to heel by imposing energy efficiency norms for cars produced in India. It seems a war was needed for the government to even recognise the importance of energy security.

Finally, I turn to the macroeconomic aspect of austerity. The term entered the Economics lexicon from the debate in the 1930s between John Maynard Keynes and Friedrich Hayek on how to deal with the Great Depression (1929-1939). Austerity had meant a compression of aggregate demand, ostensibly to revive the economy. Keynes had thought of this as the wrong thing to do, for the Depression reflected a shortage of demand due to the collapse of private investment. Hayek acknowledged the reduction in output that would follow austerity initially but thought it necessary to compensate for the excessive demand that had caused the crisis. In India today, making do with less imported oil and cooking gas may be necessary but unless substitutes are found quickly, it is likely to lead to a loss of output. If such a loss materialises, it would come on the heels of a comprehensive slowing down of the economy that commenced even before the war in West Asia — in 2024, M Parameswaran and I estimated that of the 11 sectors at the initial level of disaggregation of national income, the majority had slowed after 2014, with only real estate growing faster.

Balakrishnan is the author of India's Economy from Nehru to Modi: A Brief History



ASHOK PANKAJ, POORNIMA M
AND RAMANDEEP KAUR

IN A recent report on school education, NITI Aayog has flagged two problems. One, the persistently high number of out-of-school children, and two, weak learning outcomes that frustrate much of the hard-earned achievements of universal enrolment at the primary and upper-primary levels. With four out of 10 children aged 6-17 years not in school, a deepening crisis in learning levels, and average years of schooling lower than developed countries, the pursuit of the goals of Viksit Bharat would be challenging.

Out-of-school children are higher in rural areas, among SCs, STs and Muslims, and are concentrated in a few states. Further, it is higher in boys than in girls, because boys are often expected to support family income at an early stage.

A recent study on out-of-school children shows that high aspiration of parents for education of their children, especially among the poor and the marginalised, co-exists with high levels of disillusionment from school education, leading to withdrawal of children from schools. NFHS-5 shows that a significant proportion of adolescents disen-

Rigid administrative norms, and limited school autonomy deprive migrants, and homeless children

Not enrolment, problem is school dropouts

gage from schooling due to a lack of interest, non-fulfilment of aspirations, and discouraging school experiences. There are also other and sometimes correlated factors, like poverty, migration, gender and disability barriers, and spatial factors. General incentives like uniforms, books, mid-day meals etc. are not very effective for such children.

Second, secondary and higher secondary schools are not adequate. The distance and safety concerns of girls are barriers for their continuing school beyond upper-primary level. Language problems, inadequate infrastructure, dysfunctional WASH facilities, and the absence of a supportive learning environment are other factors.

Third, rigid administrative norms and limited school autonomy deprive migrants and homeless children. Denial of admission, non-issuing of transfer certificates, and restricted access to welfare-linked entitlements (their non-portability), non-recognition of caste certificates of other states, often hinder such enrolment.

Fourth, while policy attention has largely focussed on the 6-14 age

group, an obligation under the RTE Act, the problem is more pronounced at the secondary and higher-secondary levels. Fifth, while technology-enabled initiatives like the PRABANDH portal at the national level and the School Har Din Aaye (SHARDA) portal in UP have strengthened identification, tracking, and monitoring of out-of-school children, implementation challenges persist. Integration of technology-driven tracking mechanisms with community-level interventions can ensure completion of school education.

As India moves towards the fulfilment of the vision of "Viksit Bharat" by 2047, SDG-4 goals by 2030, and with the rollout of the NEP 2020, it is of utmost importance to recognise the gravity of the problem of out-of-school children, make a holistic assessment of its magnitude, and focus more on 14-years-plus children. There is a need to move towards strategies that recognise the interdependence of household conditions, school-side factors, and systemic and governance challenges.

Pankaj is professor, Poornima is assistant professor and Kaur is senior research associate, Council for Social Development



CHANDRIKA SOYANTAR

SHASHI THAROOR, writing in these pages ('At India-Nordic Summit, turn historical sambandh into future partnership', IE, May 14), framed the India-Nordic Summit as an opportunity to convert sambandh into strategic alignment. The missing dimension is capital. The Nordic arc spans technology, sustainability, shipping and clean energy across Denmark, Sweden, Finland and Iceland. Within it, Norway stands apart — steward of the world's largest sovereign wealth fund, at a moment when India is one of the few economies capable of absorbing long-duration capital at scale.

India, Norway need a sovereign investment corridor

Norway's Government Pension Fund Global (GPF) holds patient sovereign capital of \$2.1 trillion, which is more than half of India's GDP, and is owned by 5.5 million Norwegians — fewer than the population of Surat. The GPF's inheritance of \$382,000 per citizen against \$100,000 income — Norway's answer to Fafnir's greed — is one of the greatest acts of intergenerational discipline in modern finance and civilisation. India's share is 1.5 per cent of the portfolio — a fraction for the world's fifth-largest economy. The real question is not what each side wants. It is what the summit yields for both.

Norway has sovereign capital in search of long-duration growth. India offers one of the world's deepest long-duration growth opportunities. The India-Nordic Summit is where the two meet. Norway's krone rises

with Brent crude. India's rupee falls with every spike. In 1990, India pledged gold to avert default. That same year, Norway made its first quiet deposit into what became the GPF. Compulsion versus discipline. Oil wealth and oil dependence form a natural complementarity — one capable of funding the transition beyond oil.

Norway's GPF holds \$34.6 billion across 575 Indian companies. Between 2024 and 2025, most FPIs reduced exposure. The

Norway has sovereign capital in search of long-duration growth. India offers one of the world's deepest long-duration growth opportunities

GPF — singularly — increased. Patient. Sovereign. Counter-cyclical. Sovereign capital of this scale requires clarity, credibility, and visibility. India's National Infrastructure Pipeline — toll roads, green hydrogen, offshore wind, port logistics — is the asset class designed for such capital. The National Monetisation Pipeline 2.0 adds \$174 billion in brownfield assets. Resurgent SOEs across energy, defence and logistics add further depth. Global sovereign capital is increasingly selective. Few economies combine scale, absorption, demographics, and depth as India now does.

What is needed is not MoUs but a bespoke sovereign investment corridor — one that is ring-fenced for GPF participation, aligned with governance, tax, currency risk-sharing, and Norway's Council on Ethics.

Norway cast off its oil anchor. Discipline held. It now sails global capital markets. India, too, is casting off. The anchor is heavy. All sails are in place — wide and trimmed. For Norway, India's growth is the wind. For India, Norway's capital is the tailwind.

The Prime Minister was in Oslo for the first such visit in 43 years. The Arctic and the Indian monsoon are increasingly understood to be interconnected. The two sovereigns are linked at a level deeper than capital. The Bifrost already exists. The summit must now widen it — broad enough for the scale of flows, durable enough for their duration. The question is no longer about bilateral ties. It is about capital alignment at scale.

The writer is an investment banker and founder-director at Amarisa Capital Advisor

CLIMATE

FIFA World Cup: How humidity and heat could play spoilsport

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, May 19

IN A matter of weeks, the world is set to be gripped by football World Cup fever, as an expanded, 48-team tournament will be played in the North American summer for the first time since 1994. Before the heat rises on the pitch, a new scientific analysis by the World Weather Attribution (WWA), a climate research group, has warned that human-induced climate change has made heat stress at the upcoming World Cup more likely than in 1994.

The study found that more matches will be played under humid heat conditions, which pose health risks not only to athletes, but also to fans, officials and staff. It also mapped city and venue-specific heat stress risks.

Wet bulb temperature

Researchers from Imperial College London analysed Wet Bulb Globe Temperature (WBGT) across 16 venues in the United States, Mexico and Canada during the tournament period of June 11 to July 19. WBGT is a composite index that factors in the combined effect of humidity, sunlight and wind to determine how the human body can regulate internal heat and cool itself. It captures heat stress impact, rather than air temperature alone.

The research involved comparing today's climate with that of 1994, which was 0.7°C cooler on average. Using simulations, the researchers assessed how many venues were likely to see WBGT exceed 26°C. To be sure, a WBGT of 26°C translates to temperatures of roughly 30°C with mid to high humidity, or the equivalent of 38°C in dry heat, as per WWA.

The study found that at least 25% of the 104 World Cup matches were likely to be played at 26°C and higher wet bulb globe temperature. "Our research shows that climate change is having a real and measurable impact on the viability of holding World Cups during the northern hemisphere summer. The 1994 World Cup may not feel particularly distant to many adults today, yet half of human-induced climate change has happened since then," said Friederike Otto, one of the study's authors and professor of climate science at Imperial College.

SCIENCE OF HUMIDITY

- In humid heat, the body is unable to cool down quickly enough, making it harder to regulate body temperature and raising risks of heat exhaustion.
- With footballers exerting themselves in direct sunlight through high-intensity movements, their performance and endurance could be affected.

Health impact

Typically, in humid heat, the body is unable to cool down quickly enough, making it harder to regulate body temperature.

When the body is unable to cool down quickly enough, it increases the risk of heat exhaustion, heat stroke and cardiovascular disease. A landmark 2010 study theorised that sustained six-hour exposure to a wet-bulb temperature of 35°C could prove fatal. A March 2026 study, published in *Nature*, said that risks are rising even at temperatures below this threshold.

With footballers exerting themselves in direct sunlight through high-intensity movements, humid heat is expected to affect their performance and endurance. The FIFPRO, an organisation of professional players, has issued guidance recommending that when WBGT reaches 26°C or higher, heat strain becomes a real risk, which necessitates cooling and drink breaks. At 28°C and above, FIFPRO says it is unsafe for play.

However, FIFA, the global football governing body, will consider postponement only if WBGT levels exceed 32°C. Cooling breaks were first introduced during the 2014 World Cup in Brazil. As the US faced Portugal at Manaus, in the heart of the Amazon rainforest, the conditions were stifling at 30°C and 66% humidity. It prompted referee Nestor Pitana to pause the match for a hydration break in the 39th minute.

Concerns over desert heat prompted FIFA to move the 2022 Qatar World Cup to winter, for the first time.

Worst-affected matches

Southern, mid-west, and humid coastal venues face the prospect of high heat stress. The study identified six stadiums – New York MetLife Stadium (host of the final), Philadelphia Lincoln Financial Field, Kansas City Arrowhead Stadium, Miami Hard Rock Stadium, Boston Gillette Stadium and Estadio Monterrey in Mexico – as most likely to experience high humid heat.

Miami will likely see multiple games played at temperatures above 26°C WBGT. Dallas and Houston, which have cooled stadiums, face a 30% chance of enduring wet-bulb temperatures above 26°C. Both stadiums have cooling systems.

LAW

In stray dogs case in SC, questions of right to life, compassion to living beings

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, May 19

THE SUPREME Court on Tuesday dismissed all challenges on stray dog management and warned that the state cannot remain a "passive spectator" to the threat of dog attacks in public spaces.

The Bench, comprising Justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and N V Anjaria, said the stray dog crisis had reached alarming proportions because of poor implementation of the Animal Birth Control (ABC) framework.

Linking the issue to Article 21 of the Constitution, the court held that the right to life includes the right to move freely in public spaces without fear of attack. "The Constitution does not envisage a society where children and elderly citizens are left to survive on the mercy of physical strength or chance," it held.

What triggered the case?

The SC stepped into the stray dogs issue last July after taking suo motu cognizance of a news report about a six-year-old girl in New Delhi dying after a dog bite.

The case came before a Bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and R Mahadevan, who in August 2025 directed civic authorities across Delhi-NCR to pick up stray dogs from public places and move them to shelters. It also said the dogs should not be released back onto the streets.

This triggered protests, with animal welfare groups and others arguing that the directions were contrary to the ABC Rules. The rules require stray dogs to be sterilised and vaccinated before being released into the same area from where they were picked up.

Applications were filed in the SC seeking to have this order recalled. The matter was eventually placed before a larger three-judge Bench led by Justice Vikram Nath. The court



The SC said last year that the stray dog issue had become a public safety concern.

MAGNIFIC

softened the earlier directions and restored the sterilisation and release policy, while allowing authorities to keep rabid or aggres-

sive dogs in shelters. It also barred feeding in public spaces outside designated zones.

What was argued earlier?

Resident groups and families of dog bite victims argued that authorities had failed to control rising attacks, especially near schools, residential colonies, etc. They told the court that the issue could no longer be treated only as an animal welfare concern.

Animal welfare groups took the opposite view, arguing that mass removal of dogs was neither sustainable nor effective. As dogs are territorial animals, removing sterilised dogs from an area would only create space for unsterilised dogs to move in, which would worsen the problem.

Gradually, the hearings broadened into a review of how municipal bodies and states were implementing sterilisation, shelter and vaccination policies.

In November 2025, the SC passed another

POLITY

Why India needs to empower local bodies



EXPERTS EXPLAIN

DEVESH KAPUR & ARVIND SUBRAMANIAN

"WHATEVER THE reasons, the fact remains our local bodies are not, as a rule, shining examples of success and efficiency..." That is not a contemporary lament but one expressed in 1925 by the chairman of the municipality of Allahabad, Jawaharlal Nehru. A hundred years on, little has changed.

The third tier of government — comprising rural and urban local bodies — is prominently absent in the federalism debates, which tend to focus exclusively on the Centre and the states. It is the stepchild of Indian federalism and the offending step-parent is the second tier, namely state governments, directly above and controlling it.

Dependence on state governments

Consider the abject neglect of the urban third tier in personnel, finances and expenditures.

In the United States and China, polar opposites as political systems, nearly two-thirds of government employees work for local governments. In India, just over 10 per cent do (see *Figure 1*). As a result, most public services are delivered by the third tier in the former, very few in India.

Next, consider finances. Self-generated resources in addition to personnel are critical to efficient delivery. *Figure 2* illustrates how poor the performance of urban local bodies (ULBs) has been compared to the other two tiers. The Centre and states have been able to increase the resources they generate for themselves to fund service delivery by a factor of 2 and 2.5 respectively, over nearly six decades.

In contrast, the urban third tier's share in tax generation has broadly stagnated at a measly 0.3 per cent of GDP. As a result, expenditures by the third tier are abysmally low (less than 1 per cent of GDP) and the states and Centre spend roughly 15 and 20 times more, respectively. Poor own tax generation means that even measly expenditures are funded from outside resources, eviscerating any agency that the third tier might have and reinforcing their dependence on state governments.

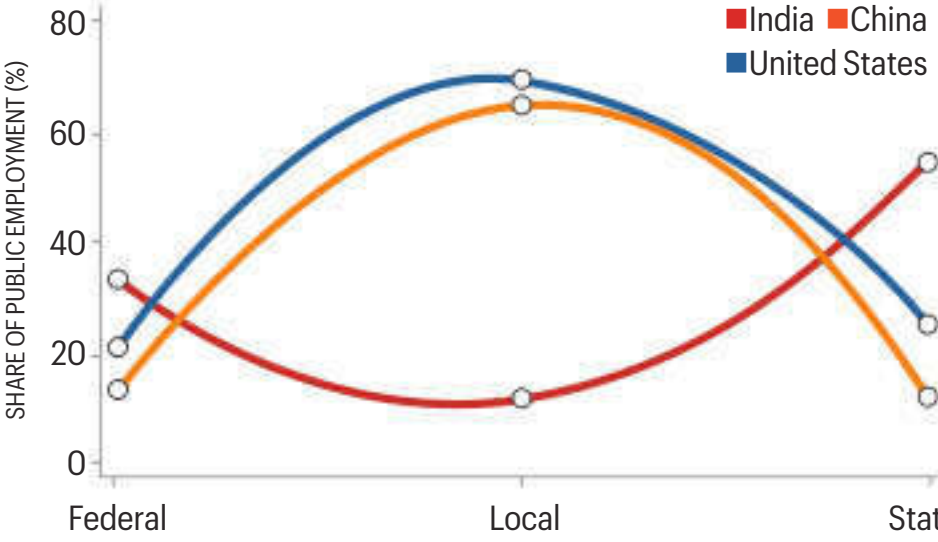
This is especially striking, given rapid urbanisation and the passage of the 73rd and 74th Amendments granting constitutional status to local governments that came into effect in 1993.

Monetising land

The deficiencies of the third tier have something to do with a deeper pathology

Where third tier of governance stands

Figure 1: Structure of employment across three tiers of government: China, India, and the United States



Own tax resources (% of GDP)

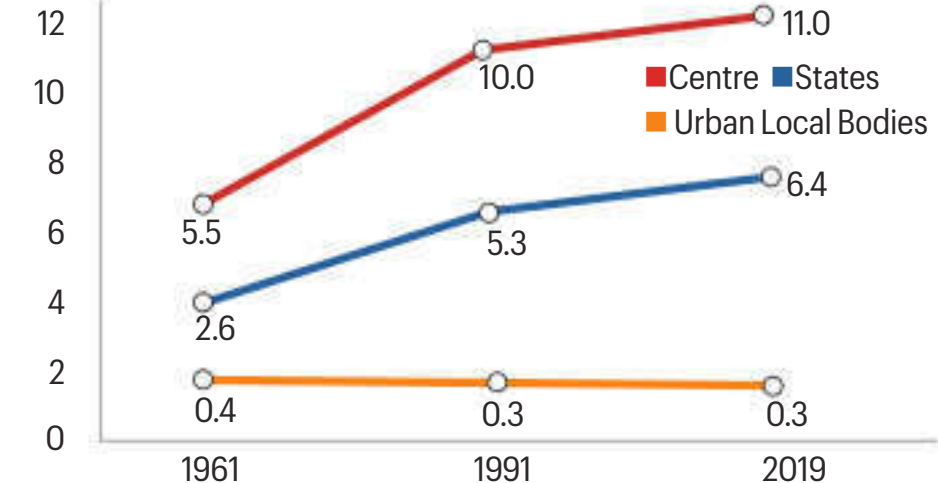


Figure 3: Tax and non-tax revenues from land, China and India, 1999-2022 (% of GDP)



relating to land. One manifestation of this is suggested by a contrast between China and India. In relatively land scarce countries, rapid economic growth leads to rapid increases in land and property values relative to gross domestic product (GDP). This has been true of China and of India. As such, land provides a potentially buoyant source of fiscal revenues.

But as *Figure 3* shows, over the period of rapid economic growth in the two countries, China was able to fiscalise rising land values, and more from selling land than taxing it. The irony was that a communist country privatised land to capture some of the revenues. China's land revenues increased from less than 1 per cent of GDP to more than 10 per cent at its peak.

In contrast, India's revenues have stagnated at about 1 per cent of GDP through

India vs the Big Two

In the US and China, nearly two-thirds of government employees work for local governments.

● In India, just over 10 per cent do.

the entire growth phase. Put differently, the Chinese government's collections from land revenue for every urban resident that was available for spending was about 15 times more than India's in 1999; at its peak in 2020, this multiple increased to 225. More rapid growth and the superior ability to fiscalise land values increased the revenue envelope for China dramatically but by very little for India.

The inability to fiscalise land owes to socialist ideology interacting with vested interests, compounded by a controlling second tier and an enfeebled third tier. Socialism inspired misguided laws such as the Urban Land Ceiling Act of 1976, which simply fragmented land into small parcels with little excess identified and a trivial amount acquired by the state for public purposes.

Even allowing for this, several state entities — mothballed public sector enterprises, ports, the defence department, state-managed temples — did have vacant or encroached-upon land which has never been monetised. The Indian state never had the monopoly on land that China had and hence could never have sold as much land as China's local bodies, but it did not even try. Scarcity is the parent of rent-seeking. But perhaps the worst outcome of these laws (along with land use controls and building by-laws) were severe distortions in land and rental markets that were a prime driver of "black money". No sector in India has been as contaminated with black money as the real estate sector.

The result is that ULBs in India are caught in a low-equilibrium political economy trap. While higher tiers (both Centre and states) use their devolution powers to control and influence lower levels, the latter are both unable and unwilling to tax their proximate citizens. The result is chronic resource constraints with high dependency: a lever of political and administrative control of local governments by states that severely constrains their autonomy.

This affliction has been particularly pernicious for ULBs, whose low managerial capacity has been a collateral damage of the stranglehold of state governments on appointments. City governments lack the power to appoint municipal commissioners and their senior management teams or over appointments, promotions and disciplining their staff. Even where the functions are notionally transferred to local bodies, the staff remains accountable to the state governments.

Is there a way forward?

Greater financial resources became available to ULBs through Central government schemes for urban development such as the Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission (JNNURM) and its successor, the Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT), that tied funding to states and cities committing themselves to structural reforms. Successive Finance Commissions have also allocated more re-

sources to the third tier in recent years.

These additional resources are still a fraction of what ULBs need. More importantly, Central schemes are top-down initiatives with little citizen participation and have been unable to address the binding constraints of weak administrative and technical capacity of ULBs and the overbearing role of state governments. The truth is that state governments that are sometimes victims of over-centralising by New Delhi are themselves perpetrators vis-à-vis their own third tier. As the economist Raja Chelliah famously said, everyone wants decentralisation but only for the higher level.

Even as India is becoming more urban, its urban infirmities are putting a brake on a key locus of innovation and growth. The debates on industrial policy and their role in boosting China's growth belie the reality that most industrial policies in China are formulated and implemented by its cities and not by bureaucrats in the national or provincial capitals. Fierce competition among cities in China reinforces the fierce competition among firms, driving that country's exceptional dynamism.

In India, the lack of competition drags it down although this is slowly beginning to happen. As New Delhi gets suffocatingly polluted and Bengaluru immobilingly congested, people and investors will seek other destinations. The rise of second and third-tier cities — Bhubaneswar, Coimbatore, Indore, Kochi, Mohali, Surat — is encouraging but needs to be supported.

The push and pull dynamic unleashed not just by competitive federalism but also by competitive sub-federalisms could emerge as a promising force for change. Another driver could emerge from the growing weight of the urban population. While this will become manifest in the new census, the resulting intra-state delimitation will give greater weight to urban voters.

Regardless, debates on Indian federalism can no longer be confined to Centre-state relations. Empowering cities and making their governance more accountable must be integrated into these debates as well. The open-air gas chamber that Delhi has remained for decades is a reminder and indictment of cities being missing in debates on federalism.

This is the second of two pieces on the federalism debate and draws upon the authors' recent book, A Sixth of Humanity: Independent India's Development Odyssey, especially Chapter XIV.

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sian crude to partly offset the loss of Gulf barrels due to the Strait of Hormuz closure. It could have been the case this time too.

Experts see such waivers as part of the Donald Trump administration's effort to prevent a sustained spike in international oil prices — and the consequent rise in domestic fuel prices in the US — given the mid-term elections later this year.

But this has attracted criticism from various sections in the US, who argue that it is leading to a windfall for Moscow, which would fund its war effort in Ukraine. Such arguments were also made against the similar waiver for the purchase of Iranian oil and fuel, after which the US didn't renew that.

India's Russian oil imports

While government officials consistently maintained that India didn't require a US

waiver to buy Russian oil, industry experts said that the waiver actually helped. It enabled Indian refiners to be able to take deliveries of Russian oil even on tankers sanctioned or blocked by the US, and they could deal directly with sanctioned Russian companies like Rosneft and Lukoil. Moreover, it temporarily removed the friction between Washington and New Delhi over the latter's hefty purchases of Moscow's crude.

Although India was buying significant volumes of Russian crude even before the West Asia war began, the quantity had reduced notably in the months that preceded the war, evidently due to the US imposing sanctions on Rosneft and Lukoil, and amid India-US trade negotiations. Washington made a meaningful reduction in New Delhi's Russian oil imports a prerequisite for scrapping its 25% additional penal tariff.

What do the ABC Rules say?

The Animal Birth Control Rules, 2023, issued under the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960, treat sterilisation and anti-rabies vaccination as the primary way to control stray dog populations. They also require dogs to be released back into the same locality after sterilisation, recognising that stray dogs are territorial by nature.

The Rules do not permit indiscriminate killing or relocation. Euthanasia is allowed only in limited situations involving rabid, terminally ill or fatally injured animals.

The case also raised constitutional concerns. Animal welfare groups relied on Article 51A(g), which asks citizens to show compassion towards living creatures. Petitioners representing residents and bite victims argued that unchecked stray dog populations affected citizens' rights under Articles 19 and 21, including the right to move freely and live safely.

Power demand hits record on second day running

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, May 19

INDIA'S PEAK electricity demand soared to an all-time high mark of 260 gigawatts (GW) on Tuesday afternoon as mercury breached the 45-degree Celsius mark in vast swathes of India, driving up the use of cooling appliances like air conditioners.

It was three notches above Monday's figure of 257 GW — which was the previous power demand record in the country.

Before Monday, April 25 saw the power demand hitting 256 GW.

Peak demand figures, whether daily or monthly, are largely statistical reference points, as they reflect the highest load recorded at any moment during a given period on a particular day, often for a brief duration.

Demand is expected to remain high throughout May, and till mid of June when monsoon brings some relief.

Heatwave alert across the country

According to the IMD's special bulletin, heat wave conditions are likely to persist across large parts of northwest, central and eastern India over the next week, with some regions likely to experience severe heat wave conditions.

In northwest India, isolated parts of Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh and New Delhi are likely to witness heat wave conditions from May 18 to May 24, IMD predicted.

Similar conditions are expected in West and East Rajas-



Peak demand hit a record 260 GW during daytime on Tuesday, beating Monday's record. REUTERS

than during the same period, along with warm nights in some areas until May 21.

Uttar Pradesh is expected to face the most intense conditions, with West and East Uttar Pradesh likely to experience heat wave to severe heat wave conditions from May 19 to May 24, along with warm nights in some pockets.

In central India, isolated heat wave conditions are forecast in Madhya Pradesh till May 24. Similarly, heatwave conditions are likely to prevail over some parts of Chhattisgarh from May 20 to May 24. In Vidarbha, too, heat wave conditions are expected until May 23.

The sustained rise in temperatures is expected to drive electricity consumption in the coming days. According to the estimates of the Ministry of Power, the peak power demand in the country is expected to touch 271 GW this year.

Night shortage persist

Meeting peak electricity de-

GRID STRAIN

TUESDAY'S PEAK electricity demand rose to 260 GW, up from Monday's 257 GW

DEMAND IS expected to remain high throughout May, and till mid of June when monsoon brings some relief

PEAK DEMAND figures are largely statistical reference points, as they reflect highest load recorded at any moment during a given period

mand during night hours continues to be a challenge, as nearly 150 GW of installed solar capacity goes offline after sunset. A similar pattern had emerged in April as temperatures began rising sharply from mid-month, leading to increased stress on the power system during night-time hours, this newspaper had earlier reported.

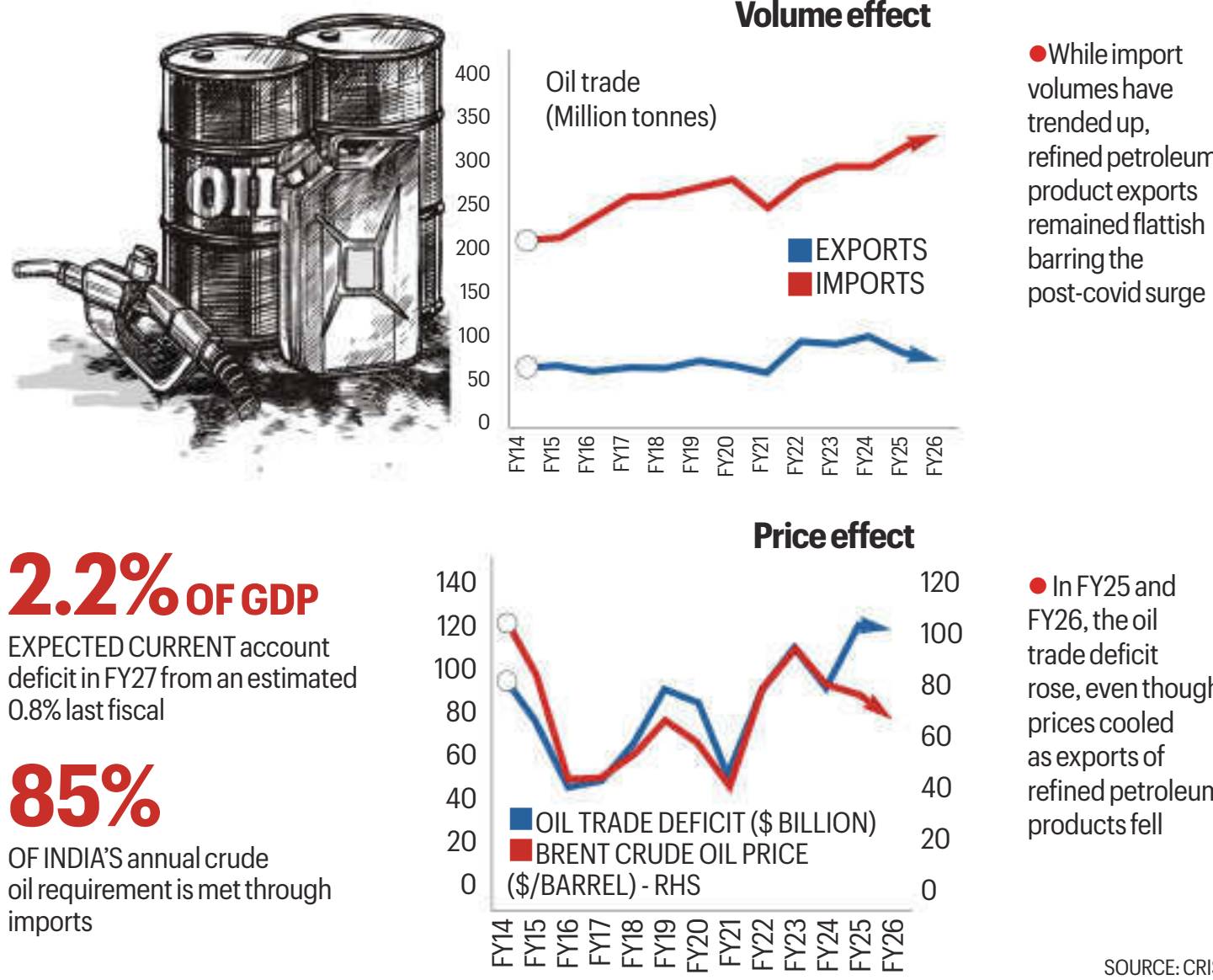
In April, the night-time power shortage shot up as high as 5.4 GW, enough to serve 2.7 million rural homes, underscoring the strain after sunset.

The strain on the power system was also reflected in spot electricity prices which have witnessed sharp increases at night reflecting gap in demand and supply.

On Tuesday, when power demand hit the all-time high mark of 260 GW, 61.5% demand was met through thermal power, while solar power contributed 22%. Wind energy's contribution was 6.7% and hydro power's share was 5.3, followed by nuclear power at 2.7%.

INDIA'S OIL TRADE DEFICIT SET TO BALLOON

The country's oil trade deficit is set to expand in the backdrop of the West Asia conflict, that has led to a surge in global Brent crude prices. According to a report by Crisil, Brent oil prices may average \$90-95 per barrel in FY27.



India to use crisis for reform, says Goyal

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, May 19

INDIA WILL convert the current difficult situation and the risks associated with global geopolitics into an opportunity for faster reform and greater resilience, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Tuesday.

"Whenever times are tough, whenever we face difficulty, that's when the best comes out of all of us. India has never let a crisis go by and the world situ-

ation is an opportunity we should engage more deeply with each other, find ways to strengthen our business processes and prepare ourselves in these uncertain times," he said at the ASSOCHAM India Business Reform Summit.

Current geopolitical problems could persist because the stakes on both sides are so high that decisions made in the morning might not be upheld by afternoon. "In such a situation, we don't need to panic. We need to be smart," he said.

This financial year the Centre is aiming for \$1 trillion exports after clocking in \$ 863 billion in 2025-26. Many key Free Trade Agreements (FTAs) with the UK, Oman and New Zealand are expected to come into effect this year. The industry should start working on benefitting from these FTAs immediately.

"Let's start going out. Take delegations across the world. Do your sampling. Do your trial orders well in advance of the FTAs coming into effect," the minister added. FE

Rupee plunges for 8th straight session; down 6.1% since war

Mumbai: The Indian rupee fell to a record low for a sixth consecutive day, ending lower for eight sessions in a row on Tuesday, weighed down by mounting external pressures as the prolonged US-Iran conflict drives a sustained rise in crude oil prices and pushes US Treasury yields higher.

The rupee slumped to a record closing low of 96.5325 per dollar, compared to the 96.3450 level it settled at on Monday.

The currency touched a record intraday low of 96.6150 and has fallen 6.1% since the Iran war broke out in late February.

"The market's biggest challenge right now is not just direction, but confidence. Until there is visible cooling in global tensions and stability in foreign flows, the rupee may continue trading under pressure," Amit Pabari, managing director at FX advisory firm CR Forex said.

"With no meaningful signs of easing in global risk factors, the pair now appears to be gradually shifting its focus toward the 97 mark."

Economists expect India's current account deficit to widen significantly, hit by higher crude oil prices and lower remittances due to the war in the West Asia.

The benchmark Brent crude has jumped over 50% since the start of the war, a major challenge for India's economy. REUTERS

RELATIONS HAVE REACHED A TRULY UNPRECEDENTED LEVEL, SAYS RUSSIAN PRESIDENT

Putin lands in China for talks with Xi

Press Trust of India
Beijing, May 19

RUSSIAN PRESIDENT Vladimir Putin arrived in Beijing on Tuesday night on a two-day state visit for talks with his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping, days after US leader Donald Trump travelled to China.

Putin was received by Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi at the airport. Ahead of his arrival, Putin said Russia-China relations have reached “a truly unprecedented level.”

In a video address on Tuesday delivered before his state visit to China, Putin noted that “regular mutual visits and Russia-China top-level talks are an important and integral part of our joint efforts to promote the entire range of relations between our two countries and unlock their truly limitless potential.”

The special nature of Russia-China relations is reflected in the atmosphere of mutual understanding and trust, a commitment to pursuing win-win and equitable cooperation, conducting respectful dialogue, and supporting each



Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi welcomes Russian President Vladimir Putin in Beijing on Tuesday. REUTERS

other on matters affecting the core interests of both countries, including protection of sovereignty and state unity, he said.

The Chinese Foreign Ministry said Xi and Putin will exchange views on bilateral ties, cooperation in various fields, as well as international and regional issues of mutual interest.

This is Putin's 25th visit to

China, foreign ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun told a media briefing here on Monday, emphasising close strategic ties between Russia and China as well as strong friendship and rapport between the two leaders.

“The two sides will take this visit as an opportunity to continue to promote the development of China-Russia relations

to a higher level, which will inject greater stability and positive energy into the world,” Guo said.

Since Xi took power in 2012, the two leaders have met dozens of times, frequently referring to each other as “dear friend” and emphasising mutual trust.

Their ties have strengthened through cooperation in trade, energy, security,

E. EXPLAINED

The ‘dear friend’ bilateral ties

RUSSIA-CHINA relations today are marked by unprecedented closeness, with Vladimir Putin's 25th visit underscoring mutual trust, strategic alignment, and shared opposition to Western pressure. Xi and Putin emphasize “dear friend” ties, deep cooperation in energy, trade, and security, and coordinated support for allies like Iran.

and efforts to counter Western influence and observers view the Xi-Putin relationship as one of the most significant political partnerships in contemporary global affairs.

Significantly, Putin is visiting Beijing days after Trump's three-day trip here from May 14 to 16, during which he held close-door talks with Xi on a host of global and bilateral issues.

Russia holds nuclear drills amid Ukrainian drone attacks

Moscow: Russia on Tuesday began massive maneuvers of its nuclear forces featuring practice launches of nuclear-capable ballistic and cruise missiles in drills that come amid surge in Ukrainian drone strikes.

The three-day exercise will involve 64,000 troops, over 200 missile launchers, more than 140 aircraft, 73 surface warships and 13 submarines, including eight armed with nuclear-tipped intercontinental ballistic missiles, the Defence Ministry said. The maneuvers will focus on the “preparation and use of nuclear forces under the threat of aggression,” the ministry said.

The drills will also practice cooperation with Belarus. Russian arsenals in Belarus include its latest intermediate range nuclear-capable Oreshnik missile system.

AP

Ebola deaths in eastern Congo rise to 131 as outbreak spreads

Reuters
Bunia (Democratic Republic of Congo), May 19

TWENTY-SIX MORE suspected Ebola deaths were recorded in 24 hours in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo, authorities said on Tuesday, and the head of the WHO expressed deep concern about the outbreak's spread.

The new deaths bring to 131 the fatalities associated with the outbreak in eastern DRC. There have been 516 suspected cases and 33 confirmed cases in DRC, according to a daily bulletin published by health authorities, and two confirmed cases in neighbouring Uganda.



A health worker screens a traveller. REUTERS

The outbreak has alarmed experts because it was able to spread for weeks undetected across a densely populated area. Butembo recorded its first two confirmed cases on Monday, Jean-Jacques Muyembe, director of Congo's National Institute for Biomedical Research (INRB), told Reuters.